

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK  
COUNTY OF BRONX

----- X  
NAQUAN JOHNSON,

Plaintiff,

-against-

THE CITY OF NEW YORK, NYPD POLICE OFFICER  
JUSTIN J. CRISTIANO SHIELD NO. 11366, NYPD  
POLICE OFFICERS JOHN/JANE DOES NUMBERS 1-  
10,

Defendants.  
----- X

**SUMMONS**

Index No.:

The Basis of Venue is:  
Location of Incident

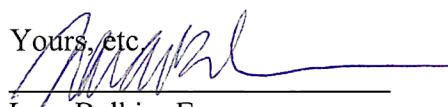
Plaintiff designates BRONX  
County as the place of trial.

**To the above named Defendants:**

**You are hereby summoned** to answer the Verified Complaint in this action, and to serve a copy of your Verified Answer to the Verified Complaint, or, if the Verified Complaint is not served with this Summons, to serve a notice of appearance on the Plaintiff's attorneys within twenty days after the service of this Summons, exclusive of the day of service, where service is made by delivery upon you personally within the state, or, within 30 days after completion of service where service is made in any other manner. In case of your failure to appear or answer, judgment will be taken against you by default for the relief demanded in the complaint.

DATED: New York, New York  
May 12, 2023

Yours, etc

  
\_\_\_\_\_  
Lara Belkin, Esq.

Shulman-Hill, PLLC

*Attorneys for Plaintiff*

1 State Street Plaza

15<sup>th</sup> Floor

New York, New York 10004

(212) 203-1090

TO: THE CITY OF NEW YORK, Corporation Counsel, 100 Church Street, NY, NY 10007

NYPD Police Officer Justin J. Cristiano, Shield No. 11366 – Bronx 49<sup>th</sup> Precinct, 2121  
Eastchester Road, Bronx, NY

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK  
COUNTY OF BRONX

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NAQUAN JOHNSON,

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THE CITY OF NEW YORK, NYPD POLICE OFFICER  
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INDEX NO.:

VERIFIED COMPLAINT

JURY TRIAL DEMANDED

Plaintiff **Naquan Johnson**, by his attorneys, Shulman-Hill, PLLC, as and for his Verified Complaint herein, alleges upon information and belief as follows:

### PRELIMINARY STATEMENT

1. This is a civil rights action to recover money damages arising out of defendants' violation of Plaintiff's rights as secured by the Civil Rights Act, 42 U.S.C. Sections 1983 and 1988, and of rights secured by the Fourth, Fifth and Fourteenth Amendments to the United States Constitution, and the common law and the laws of the State of New York. On October 27, 2022, at approximately 02:45 p.m., Plaintiff Naquan Johnson, while lawfully in the vicinity of 2121 Eastchester Road, County of Bronx, State of New York, was subject to an unlawful arrest, detention and unlawful search by defendant Detective and Police Officers. In addition, Plaintiff was subjected to approximately thirty (30) hours in unlawful custody at the 49th Precinct and Bronx County Central Booking. Plaintiff was deprived of his rights under 2021 N.Y.C. Local Law No. 48, N.Y.C. Admin. Code §§ 8 – 802 and his constitutional, common law, and statutory rights when the individual defendants unlawfully stopped, detained, and passed along false accusations to prosecuting attorneys in violation of the Fourth, Fifth and Fourteenth Amendments to the United States Constitution, the common law and the laws of the State of New York.

### PARTIES

2. Plaintiff Naquan Johnson is a resident of the state of New York.
3. NYPD Police Officer Justin J. Cristiano, Shield No. 11366, was at all times relevant herein an officer, employee, and agent of the New York City Police Department.

4. At all times relevant herein, NYPD Police Officer Justin J. Cristiano, Shield No. 11366, was assigned to the NYPD 49<sup>th</sup> Precinct.

5. NYPD Police Officer Justin J. Cristiano, Shield No. 11366, is being sued in his individual and official capacities.

6. New York City Police Officers John Does #1-10 are and were at all times relevant herein officers, employees, and agents of the New York City Police Department.

7. Police Officers John Does #1-10 are being sued in their individual and official capacities.

8. At all times relevant herein, the individual defendants were acting under color of state law in the course and scope of their duties and functions as agents, servants, employees and officers of the New York City Police Department, and otherwise performed and engaged in conduct incidental to the performance of their lawful functions in the course of their duties. They were acting for and on behalf of the New York City Police Department at all times relevant herein, with the power and authority vested in them as officers, agents and employees of the New York City Police Department and incidental to the lawful pursuit of their duties as officers, employees and agents of the New York City Police Department.

9. Defendant City of New York is a municipal entity created and authorized under the laws of the State of New York. It is authorized by law to maintain a police department, which acts as its agent in the area of law enforcement and for which it is ultimately responsible. The defendant City of New York assumes the risks incidental to the maintenance of a police force and the employment of police officers as said risks attach to the public consumers of the services provided by the New York City Police Department.

10. Plaintiff in furtherance of his causes of action brought pursuant to New York State law filed a timely Notice of Claim against the City of New York in compliance with the Municipal Law Section 50 and in accordance with New York State law.

11. In accordance with New York State law and General Municipal Law Section 50, Plaintiff testified at a hearing held pursuant to General Municipal Law Section 50-H on February 24, 2023.

12. More than thirty (30) days have elapsed since service of said Notice of Claim was filed and the City of New York has failed to pay or adjust the claims.

13. This action falls within one or more of the exceptions as set forth in CPLR Section 1602, involving intentional actions, as well as the defendant, and/or defendants, having acted in reckless disregard for the safety of others, as well as having performed intentional acts.

14. Plaintiff has sustained damages in an amount in excess of the jurisdictional limits of all the lower Courts of the State of New York.

### STATEMENT OF FACTS

15. On October 27, 2022, at approximately 02:45 pm., Plaintiff was lawfully present in the vicinity of 2121 Eastchester Road, County of Bronx, State of New York, when the defendant Police Officers unlawfully arrested Plaintiff without probable cause or legal justification.

16. Prior to his unlawful arrest, Plaintiff had reported to parole as scheduled and, upon doing so, was seized by defendant officers, absent reasonable suspicion that he had engaged in criminal conduct or probable cause for arrest.

17. Plaintiff was waiting to meet with his parole officer at the parole office when he was called to a back room.

18. Approximately fifteen (15) Defendant Officers approached Plaintiff and, absent probable cause or reasonable suspicion that Plaintiff was involved in any criminal activity, three (3) of those officers grabbed Plaintiff and shoved him against the wall.

19. Defendant Officers then grabbed Plaintiff's arms, pinned them behind his back, and put metal handcuffs on his wrists.

20. At no point did Plaintiff resist the unlawful arrest.

21. Plaintiff officers then conducted an illegal pat-down search of Plaintiff, which yielded no weapons or other illegal contraband.

22. During the illegal pat-down Defendant Officers took Plaintiff's phone and keys without providing a voucher for those belongings.

23. Plaintiff was transported in an NYPD vehicle, in handcuffs, to the 49<sup>th</sup> precinct and placed in a holding cell.

24. Plaintiff asked numerous times why he was being arrested and defendant officers refused to answer his questions.

25. At no time relevant herein did Mr. Johnson commit a crime or violate the law in any way, nor did the police officers have an objective credible reason to accuse him of so doing.

26. Eventually Plaintiff was brought to an interrogation room by defendant Officer Cristiano, Shield No. 11366, where he was interrogated without first being informed of his Miranda rights.

27. Plaintiff was held in the 49<sup>th</sup> precinct for approximately nine (9) hours.

28. Lacking probable cause or an articulable, credible reason to believe that Plaintiff was engaged in unlawful conduct, Defendant Officers transported Plaintiff to Central Booking in handcuffs, where he was again searched and photographed Plaintiff.

29. Plaintiff was held overnight in Central Booking for approximately ten (10) hours before being taken to the courthouse.

30. While Mr. Johnson was in custody, the defendant police officers provided the Bronx County District Attorney's Office with the false, misleading and/or incomplete information that Plaintiff committed a crime.

31. After waiting all day for his case to be called, Plaintiff was suddenly escorted out of a side door of Bronx Criminal Court without seeing a judge.

32. On or about October 28, 2022, the Bronx District Attorney's Office declined to prosecute Plaintiff on the baseless allegations of defendant officers.

33. Some of the police officer defendants observed the violation of Plaintiff's rights under the Constitution of the United States and New York State Law and did nothing to prevent their fellow officers from unjustifiably arresting, confining, and using excessive force against Plaintiff.

34. The unlawful arrest, confinement, and detention by the individually named defendants caused Mr. Johnson to sustain psychological and emotional trauma.

### **FIRST CAUSE OF ACTION**

#### **Negligence**

35. The Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges each and every allegation contained in the foregoing paragraphs with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

36. Defendants owed a duty of care to Plaintiff.

37. To the extent defendants claim that the injuries to Plaintiff by the defendant police officers were unintentionally caused and that the force used by the defendants against him was unintentional, then the defendants breached that duty of care by, among other things, seizing and handcuffing him.

38. As a direct and proximate result of such acts, defendants deprived Plaintiff of his rights under the laws of the State of New York.

39. All of the foregoing occurred without any fault or provocation by Plaintiff.

40. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

41. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

42. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, Plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to emotional and psychological injuries.

### **SECOND CAUSE OF ACTION** **Unlawful Stop, Question, and Search**

43. The Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

44. The illegal approach, pursuit, stop and grab employed by defendants herein terminated Plaintiff's freedom of movement through means intentionally applied.

45. The conduct of defendants in approaching, stopping, and grabbing Plaintiff was performed under color of law and without any reasonable suspicion of criminality or other constitutionally required grounds.

46. As a direct and proximate result of such acts, defendants deprived Plaintiff of his rights under the laws of the State of New York.

47. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

48. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

### **THIRD CAUSE OF ACTION** **Violation of Fourth and Fourteenth Amendment Rights:** **Unlawful Seizure and Deprivation of Liberty**

49. The Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

50. The individually named police officer defendants, while acting in concert and within the scope of their authority, caused Plaintiff to be seized, unlawfully searched, falsely arrested, falsely imprisoned, and maliciously prosecuted without reasonable suspicion and/or probable cause, in violation of Plaintiff's right to be free of an unreasonable seizure under the

Fourth Amendment of the Constitution of the United States and to be free of a deprivation of liberty under the Fourteenth Amendment to the Constitution of the United States.

51. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, Plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to physical, emotional, and psychological injuries.

#### FOURTH CAUSE OF ACTION

##### **False Imprisonment**

52. The Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

53. The acts and conduct of the defendants constitute false arrest and false imprisonment under the laws of the State of New York. Defendants intended to confine Plaintiff and, in fact, confined Plaintiff, and Plaintiff was conscious of the confinement. In addition, Plaintiff did not consent to the confinement and the confinement was not otherwise privileged.

54. As a direct and proximate result of such acts, defendants deprived Plaintiff of his rights under the laws of the State of New York and the United States Constitution.

55. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

56. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

57. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, Plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to loss of liberty, emotional and psychological injuries.

#### FIFTH CAUSE OF ACTION

##### **Negligent Infliction of Emotional Distress**

58. The Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges each and every allegation contained in the foregoing paragraphs with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

59. By the actions described herein, defendants, each acting individually and in concert with each other, engaged in extreme and outrageous conduct, conduct utterly intolerable in a civilized community, which negligently caused severe emotional distress to Plaintiff.

60. The acts and conduct of the defendants were the direct and proximate cause of injury and damage to Plaintiff and violated Plaintiff's statutory and common law rights as guaranteed Plaintiff by the laws and Constitution of the State of New York.

61. As a direct and proximate result of such acts, defendants deprived Plaintiff of his rights under the laws of the State of New York.

62. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

63. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

64. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, Plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to emotional and psychological injuries.

### SIXTH CAUSE OF ACTION

#### **Negligent Hiring, Retention, Training and Supervision**

65. The Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges each and every allegation contained in the foregoing paragraphs with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

66. The City of New York and its employees, servants and/or agents acting within the scope of their employment did negligently hire, retain, train and supervise defendants, individuals who were unfit for the performance of police duties on the aforementioned dates at the aforementioned locations.

67. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, Plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to physical, emotional and psychological injuries.

### SEVENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

#### **Failure to Intervene**

68. The Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges each and every allegation contained in the foregoing paragraphs with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

69. The defendants that did not physically touch Plaintiff, but were present when other officers violated Plaintiff's Constitutional Rights had an affirmative duty to intervene on behalf of Plaintiff, whose constitutional rights were being violated in their presence by other officers.

70. Defendants failed to intervene to prevent the unlawful conduct described herein.



71. As a result of the foregoing, Plaintiff suffered serious, debilitating and permanent injury, his liberty was restricted for an extended period of time, he was put in fear for his safety, and he was humiliated and subject to other physical constraints.

72. As a direct and proximate result of such acts, defendants deprived Plaintiff of his rights under the laws of the State of New York.

73. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

74. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

75. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, Plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to emotional and psychological injuries.

### EIGHTH CAUSE OF ACTION

#### **Individual Defendant Officer's Violation of Plaintiff's AC 8-802 Rights**

76. The Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

77. The acts of Defendant Officers constituted conduct under color of any law, ordinance, rule, regulation, custom, or usage.

78. The acts of Defendant Officers caused Plaintiff to be deprived of his rights under 2021 N.Y.C. Local Law No. 48, N.Y.C. Admin. Code §§ 8 – 802, to wit: to be secure in his person, house, papers, and effects against unreasonable searches and seizures, and to be secure against the use of excessive force regardless of whether such force is used in connection with a search or seizure.

79. The Defendant Officers, while in uniform, unlawfully seized, frisked, and searched the Plaintiff, before detaining plaintiff and further causing his detention for approximately three (3) days in total.

80. By reason of the acts and omissions by Defendants described above, Plaintiff has endured physical and emotional injuries and was otherwise damaged and injured.

### NINTH CAUSE OF ACTION

#### **Individual Defendant Officer's Failure to Intervene in Violation of Plaintiff's AC 8-802 Rights**

81. The Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

82. The acts of Defendant Officers constituted conduct under color of any law, ordinance, rule, regulation, custom or usage.

83. Defendant Officers had a duty to protect Plaintiff from violations of his rights under 2021 N.Y.C. Local Law No. 48, N.Y.C. Admin. Code §§ 8 – 802, to wit: to be secure in his person, house, papers, and effects against unreasonable searches and seizures, and to be secure against the use of excessive force regardless of whether such force is used in connection with a search or seizure.

84. The Defendants that did not physically touch Plaintiff, but were present when other officers violated Plaintiff's AC 8-802 right against unreasonable search and seizure and excessive force had an affirmative duty to intervene on behalf of Plaintiff, whose constitutional rights were being violated in their presence by other officers.

85. Defendants failed to intervene to prevent the unlawful conduct described herein, thereby failed in their duty to intervene to protect Plaintiff from violation of his rights.

86. By reason of the acts and omissions by Defendants described above, Plaintiff has endured physical and emotional injuries and was otherwise damaged and injured.

#### TENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

#### **City-Employer's Liability for Defendant Officer's Violation of Plaintiff's AC 8-802 Rights**

126. The Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

127. Defendant Officers are "covered individuals," as defined in 2021 N.Y.C. Local Law No. 48, N.Y.C. Admin. Code §§ 8 - 801 in that they are employees of the Police Department or persons appointed by the Police Commissioner as a Special Patrolman.

128. The City of New York, as the employer of the covered individual Defendant Officers, is liable to the Plaintiff for the wrongdoing of the covered individual Defendant Officers.

129. The acts of Defendant Officers constituted conduct under color of any law, ordinance, rule, regulation, custom or usage.

130. The acts of Defendant Officers caused Plaintiff to be deprived of his rights under 2021 N.Y.C. Local Law No. 48, N.Y.C. Admin. Code §§ 8 – 802, to wit: to be secure in his person, house, papers, and effects against unreasonable searches and seizures, and to be

secure against the use of excessive force regardless of whether such force is used in connection with a search or seizure.

131. The Defendant Officers, while in uniform, unlawfully seized, frisked, and searched the Plaintiff, before detaining plaintiff and further causing his detention for approximately three (3) days in total.

132. By reason of the acts and omissions by Defendants described above, Plaintiff has endured physical and emotional injuries and was otherwise damaged and injured.

### ELEVENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

#### **City-Employer's Liability for Defendant Officer's Failure to Intervene in Violation of Plaintiff's AC 8-802 Rights**

133. The Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges the foregoing paragraphs as if the same were fully set forth at length herein.

134. Defendant Officers are "covered individuals," as defined in 2021 N.Y.C. Local Law No. 48, N.Y.C. Admin. Code §§ 8 - 801 in that they are employees of the Police Department or persons appointed by the Police Commissioner as a Special Patrolman.

135. The City of New York, as the employer of the covered individual Defendant Officers, is liable to the Plaintiff for the wrongdoing of the covered individual Defendant Officers.

136. The acts of Defendant Officers constituted conduct under color of any law, ordinance, rule, regulation, custom or usage.

137. Defendant Officers had a duty to protect Plaintiff from violations of his rights under 2021 N.Y.C. Local Law No. 48, N.Y.C. Admin. Code §§ 8 – 802, to wit: to be secure in his person, house, papers, and effects against unreasonable searches and seizures, and to be secure against the use of excessive force regardless of whether such force is used in connection with a search or seizure.

138. The Defendants that did not physically touch Plaintiff but were present when other officers violated Plaintiff's AC 8 – 802 rights against unreasonable search and seizure and excessive force had an affirmative duty to intervene on behalf of Plaintiff, whose constitutional rights were being violated in their presence by other officers.

139. Defendants failed to intervene to prevent the unlawful conduct described herein, thereby failed in their duty to intervene to protect Plaintiff from violation of his rights.

140. By reason of the acts and omissions by Defendants described above, Plaintiff has endured physical and emotional injuries and was otherwise damaged and injured.

TWELFTH CAUSE OF ACTION**Violation of Article I, § 12 of the New York State Constitution**

87. Plaintiff repeats, reiterates, and re-alleges each and every allegation contained in the above paragraphs with the same force and effect as if fully set forth herein.

88. Such conduct breached the protections guaranteed to plaintiff by the New York State Constitution, including but not limited to, Article 1, §§ 1, 6, 8, 9, 11, and 12, and including the following rights:

- i. freedom from unreasonable search and seizure of his person and property;
- ii. freedom from arrest without probable cause;
- iii. freedom from false imprisonment, that being wrongfully detained without good faith, reasonable suspicion, or legal justification, and of which wrongful detention plaintiff was aware and did not consent;
- iv. freedom from the lodging of false charges against him by police officers and prosecutors, including on information and belief, by some or all of the individual defendants; and
- v. freedom from deprivation of liberty without due process of law.

89. As a direct and proximate result of defendants' deprivations of Plaintiff's rights, privileges, and immunities guaranteed by the New York State Constitution, Plaintiff suffered physical, economic and emotional injuries, as well as a deprivation of liberty.

90. As a result of the above tortious conduct, Plaintiff was caused to suffer physical, economic, and emotional injuries, as well as a deprivation of liberty.

91. As a result of the above unconstitutional conduct, the City of New York is liable for the conduct of the Individual Defendants and any damages they caused under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

JURY DEMAND

141. Plaintiff hereby demands trial by jury of all issues properly triable thereby.

PRAYER FOR RELIEF

**WHEREFORE**, Plaintiff **Naquan Johnson** demands judgment against the defendants on each cause of action in amounts to be determined upon the trial of this action which exceeds the jurisdiction of lower courts, inclusive of punitive damages and attorneys' fees inclusive of costs and disbursements of this action, interest and such other relief as is appropriate under the law, and that the Plaintiff recover the cost of the suit herein, including reasonable attorney's fees pursuant to 42 U.S.C. § 1988 and 2021 N.Y.C. Local Law No. 48, N.Y.C. Admin. Code §§ 8 – 801 *et seq.*

Dated: New York, New York  
May 12, 2023

By: 

Lara Belkin, Esq.  
Shulman-Hill, PLLC  
*Attorneys for Plaintiff*  
1 State Street Plaza  
15<sup>th</sup> Floor  
New York, New York 10004  
(212) 203-1090

TO: THE CITY OF NEW YORK, Corporation Counsel, 100 Church Street, NY, NY 10007

NYPD Police Officer Justin J. Cristiano, Shield No. 11366 – Bronx 49<sup>th</sup> Precinct, 2121  
Eastchester Road, Bronx, NY

**ATTORNEY'S VERIFICATION**

**LARA BELKIN**, an attorney duly admitted to practice before the Courts of the

State of New York, affirms the following to be true under the penalties of perjury:

I am a partner of the law firm of **SHULMAN-HILL PLLC**, I have read the annexed **VERIFIED COMPLAINT** and know the contents thereof, and the same are true to my knowledge, except those matters therein which are stated to be alleged upon information and belief, and as to those matters I believe them to be true. My belief, as to those matters therein not stated upon knowledge, is based upon facts, records, and other pertinent information contained in my files. The reason this verification is made by me and not Plaintiff is because Plaintiff does not reside in the county wherein I maintain my office.

DATED: New York, New York  
May 12, 2023



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LARA BELKIN, ESQ.